How Deadly Airbags Are Getting Inside Cars

Podcast: Wall street journal

AI Executive Summary

Core Thesis The episode investigates a growing and lethal crisis within the automotive aftermarket: the proliferation of counterfeit and non-compliant airbag inflators being sold through online marketplaces like eBay and Facebook Marketplace. While airbags are designed to save lives, these "mini explosive devices" are being replaced with cheap, unverified alternatives that explode with enough force to cause severe injury or death. The decentralized nature of the used car market and the difficulty of policing global e-commerce platforms have created a regulatory "whack-a-mole" scenario where authorities struggle to track and recall thousands of potentially deadly parts already in circulation.

Key Arguments & Data * **The Human Toll:** The report documents multiple fatalities and severe injuries—including a 17-year-old, a middle school teacher, and a 20-year-old—caused by airbags exploding into fragments rather than inflating safely. One survivor, Uesok Kang, suffered permanent facial disfigurement due to metal pieces from an airbag explosion. * **Economic Incentives for Counterfeiting:** A significant driver of this crisis is the price discrepancy in the repair market. While a genuine airbag replacement from an automaker can cost approximately $1,000, counterfeit versions available online cost a tiny fraction of that price, creating high demand among budget-conscious repair shops and used car dealers. * **Supply Chain Complexity & Criminality:** * Investigations identified specific part numbers linked to "DTN Airbag," a Chinese company, found in the bodies of accident victims. * A global counterfeiting ring was uncovered involving manufacturers/assemblers in China and the UK, with parts being smuggled into the U.S. inside innocuous items like toys and dollhouses. * A former North Carolina transportation official was recently convicted for importing approximately 2,500 counterfeit airbags to sell on Facebook Marketplace. * **The Failure of Traditional Recall Mechanisms:** In the new car market, NHTSA can trigger recalls through dealerships who have direct contact with owners. However, in the used car market—where parts are often installed by independent mechanics using parts from unverified online sources—the chain of ownership is broken, making a systematic recall nearly impossible. * **Regulatory Struggles:**

While NHTSA has begun banning specific DTN-labeled parts and working with tech companies to trace buyers, platforms like eBay and Facebook note that while they prohibit counterfeits, the sheer volume of listings makes total prevention extremely difficult.

Actionable Takeaways * Audit Vehicle History via VIN: When purchasing a used vehicle, use services like Carfax to specifically check for any "airbag deployment" history associated with the Vehicle Identification Number (VIN). * **Scrutinize Repair Records:** If buying a used car that has been in an accident, demand documentation proving that all safety components (especially airbags) were replaced using OEM (Original Equipment Manufacturer) parts rather than aftermarket or third-party online replacements. * **Avoid "Too Good to Be True" Pricing in Repairs:** For consumers managing their own vehicle repairs, avoid sourcing critical safety components from unverified sellers on social media marketplaces or discount auction sites, as the cost savings may be offset by extreme physical risk.

Full Transcript

Live from New York, it's the Journal. That's right, Jess and I are back with another live show in New York City. This time on Wednesday, September 9th. We're going to be at City Winery for an evening of sharp reporting, insider conversation, and special guests. And probably wine? I hope so. Either way, you won't want to miss it. Tickets are on sale now. Check out the link in our show notes. See you there. A few years ago, Uesok Kang was living in Texas, where he was going to flight school. He was driving along a Texas highway in a used Chevy Malibu. He had bought earlier that year. And he lost control of his car while he was driving. Kang is originally from South Korea. Our colleague Ryan Felton recently interviewed him about that night through a translator. Walk through from there just what happened in the moments before he lost control of the car.

Kang's car slid across the road, right into the path of a pickup truck. The two collided and Kang's front airbag went off and the car came to a stop. He started to take stock of what had happened. And then I tried to call a friend who was, like, on a meet. But, you know, I got connected, but I could not talk. I could not physically speak. That's when I first realized, oh, this could be very serious. King's face was badly injured. But the thing that hurt him wasn't the other vehicle. It was something inside his own car, his airbag. Metal pieces inside the airbag blew apart and severely damaged his jaw, neck, and face. He underwent three surgeries in the month after the accident. He's had other procedures since then and more or less had to have skin moved to his jaw in order to be able to open and close his mouth like he would normally. All things considered, Kang was lucky. He survived the accident and moved on with his life.

albeit with some scars. But that's not been the case for other people that this has happened to. I am one of the very few survivors. 10 people have died and three people have been severely injured. There's a 17-year-old high school senior whose mom bought her the first car. She died after this airbag exploded. There was a middle school teacher. She died after her car had one of these airbag parts explode. A 20-year-old kid in Mississippi, he died earlier this year after the airbag exploded. The airbags that are exploding

are believed to be counterfeit, and regulators are having a hard time tracking them down, or even figuring out how many there are on the road right now. They roughly estimate there could be 10,000 of them, but they really don't know, and it just kind of amounts to this really terrible game of whack-a-mole. Welcome to the Journal.

our show about money, business, and power. I'm Ryan Knudsen. It's Friday, July 24th. Coming up on the show, the bomb lurking inside some cars. It's almost too obvious to point out that airbags exist to save lives. That's why they were initially rolled out back in the 1970s. They were kind of designed in response to people overwhelmingly refusing to wear their seatbelts, you know, blink or not. Sort of like a fallback, I guess. Yeah. You won't put on the thing that we know will help you. Right. They're known to be responsible for saving, you know, at this point it's now 50,000 lives, over 30 years. And they're pretty sophisticated devices. Every airbag includes sensors to recognize when a crash is happening, an inflator to blow up the bag, and then the cloth airbag itself.

and everything has to work in a split second. They're now mandatory, and they're heavily regulated by a federal body called the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration, or NITSA. They're essentially like a mini explosive device, so you have like the regulations around the type of chemicals that are used, their design and how they're supposed to inflate when a crash happens. In a new car fresh off the assembly line, Airbags are generally considered to be trustworthy. The issue is when an airbag has to be replaced, like after a crash. That's much more common in the used car market where the vehicle's history isn't always clear. It's just a different market where you're really kind of going off the word of the dealers who are selling them, the Carfax reports being accurate if you're looking at them. Through court documents.

Ryan was able to recreate the path of one defective airbag that made its way into a used car in Florida, a 2020 Chevy Malibu. The car originally was used as a rental car. In this case, Enterprise had it as a rental car. The rental got into an accident that was severe enough to cause the airbags to go off. The car was then sold at an auction. The person who bought it went and got an airbag to put into the car on eBay. The person who bought it runs a repair

shop and installed the aftermarket airbag. The car was then resold to a used car dealer. And then it got resold to this mother of two in Florida who had the airbag go off and exploded instead of just kind of properly inflating. Her name was Destiny Bayasi. Ryan says the crash she was in would have been survivable.

But instead, after that airbag exploded, she died. Biosy's family ended up suing, and her case hit the local news. A lawsuit alleges her driver's side airbag system included counterfeit and non-compliant components, and that several fragments from the blast struck her in the face, head, and neck, ultimately killing her. The auction house, the used car dealer, and enterprise all said they were not aware of the faulty repair. The repair shop settled the lawsuit and declined a comment. Deadly parts, like the one that killed Byasi and that injured Kang, usually trigger a recall. In 99.99% cases, when auto safety regulators learn of a defect, they basically can go to the automaker and say like, hey, do a recall. During a recall of a part in a new car, car dealerships know who they sold their cars to so they can get in touch with them and tell them something needs to be replaced. But with used cars, especially ones that have been repaired by a mechanic outside a dealership, that system breaks down. These faulty airbag parts are being bought and sold online from sites like eBay or Facebook Marketplace. The Knitz investigators have had to like essentially back their way into figuring out who sold it, who bought it, and it's like a very unwieldy process. As a result, a typical car recall is basically impossible.

So, how do you even begin to track down where these faulty airbags are coming from? That's after the break. Since 2023, cases of airbag-related fatalities have grown, and investigators started seeing a pattern. It had to do with the airbags' inflators. That's the part Ryan described earlier, it's like a mini explosive device. The inflators have, like, serial numbers and part numbers, and there was a specific part number that was visible in many of these crashes. It was essentially a clue to start on when when digging into this. In at least one instance, the inflator parts weren't just present at the scene. They were physically lodged inside a victim. There was a really jarring case of a middle-aged man in Arizona. They found a shard of glass in his neck that had the unique part number on it. The part number on that piece in the driver's neck was linked to a company in China.

known as DTN Airbag. They're pretty much just an obscure company that I don't think really anyone more or less knew, at least in the auto industry, who they were until people essentially started Googling and searching for like what this part number meant. DTN has been selling airbag inflators for years. But DTN says they didn't make these airbag inflators and that they're not responsible. They basically said, We don't sell in the United States. We don't know how this product got there. We're not even sure if it's our product. You know, anyone who buys it, it's on them to certify and do tests to ensure that it's safe. Either way, parts labeled as DTNs were showing up in airbags in the U.S. In large part, because they're so cheap. A real airbag replacement from an automaker can run you a thousand dollars. So...

There's incentive if you can find an airbag that's you know, you think is is solid in genuine That's hundreds of dollars or you know, even one tenth of the cost There's there's a clear economic incentive as to why you might seek out airbags on online Marketplaces So there's a big demand for less expensive options and counterfeiters have stepped in to fill that demand Some counterfeit airbags are actually smuggled into the US like the red drug or an endangered species. In some cases, we were told that these were showing up at ports stuffed inside things like toys and doll houses. Over the last decade, more than a dozen people have been convicted by the Justice Department for selling counterfeit airbags. And a single unscrupulous importer can bring in thousands of potentially faulty ones.

The most recent person was a former North Carolina State Transportation Department employee. They had found that he, over a two-year period through early to mid-2024, he was importing airbags and then would turn around and sell them on Facebook Marketplace. The man imported about 2,500 counterfeit airbags with the logos of several automakers on them. He wasn't acting alone. He was part of a larger counterfeiting ring that was also selling parts with DTN logos on them, according to regulators. His case kind of exposed this ring involving folks from the United Kingdom who were buying these parts that were tied to this company from China, assembling them into airbags and being shipped over here. In that case, the importer ended up being convicted of selling counterfeit goods and he went to jail for just over a year.

The U.S. Attorney's Office who investigated the case involving the North Carolina employee said, quote, the worry here is that a bunch of consumers are going to unwittingly purchase bombs and put them in their steering columns. But ultimately, the thing that authorities were able to pin on him wasn't that he was selling potentially deadly car parts. It was for a trademark violation. Still, federal investigators are trying to take action. Throughout 2025, NHTSA and investigators were learning of more accidents. And then in October, they officially opened up an investigation to try to get more detailed information from DTN and also from websites that have been found to be selling counterfeit airbags in the past, like Facebook and eBay. eBay is cooperating with NHTSA's investigation. It said it works diligently to prevent and remove unsafe product listings and that it prohibits counterfeit products.

Facebook said its rules prohibit the purchase, sale, or trade of certain vehicle parts and accessories, including airbags. Following its investigation, NHTSA ended up banning the parts of the DTN label that are linked to the fatalities. It also worked with tech companies to trace who they thought bought the products online and send them letters of warning. But beyond that, they're pretty much just trying to raise awareness. That's essentially all they can do. So what can... What can consumers do? How can people keep themselves safe? The shortest answer is, if you're going to look for a car and it has some accident history reported with it, the first thing to know is, did the airbags go off in that accident? Carfax lets you check for airbag deployments associated with your unique vehicle identification number. So it basically amounts to like, you got to know your vehicle's history.

Nobody knows for sure how many of these dangerous airbag inflators are still out there. The most recent known crash where a faulty DTN marked inflator went off was just this past June in Louisville, Kentucky. I mean, it feels like this is a sort of also sort of a story about like the race to the bottom in online in online marketplaces that like anybody in the world can put something on Amazon or eBay or on a website and sell it and that's Kind of great because you know now you can get cheap stuff, but like in this case we're talking about an airbag like a critical piece of safety technology It's not like it's a t-shirt or a toaster It's tough. It's tough to it's tough to know what to say because like so many things have gone wrong to

light to this situation and there's a very substantial number of people who sell stuff on the internet and it does include things like safety devices and we're just sort of seeing the really kind of like potentially terrifying results of that. By the way, this Sunday we have another episode in our special series about all the ways that work is changing. Last Sunday's episode was about influencers and this week it's about working from home. I hope you'll check it out. That's all for today. Friday, July 24th. The journal is a co-production of Spotify and the Wall Street Journal.

The show is made by Laura Benchoff, Catherine Brewer, Evelyn Vajardo-Alvarez, Pia Gedcari, Max Green, Sophie Codner, Matt Quang, Colin McNulty, Jessica Mendoza, Laura Morris, Enrique Perez De La Rosa, Sarah Platt, Alan Rodriguez Espinoza, Heather Rogers, Pierce Singy, Jivica Verma, Katherine Whalen, Tatiana Zamis, and me, Ryan Knudson. Our engineers are Griffin Tanner, Nathan Singapok, and Peter Leonard. And this is Laura Benchoff's last week with us. Laura, we're gonna miss you so much. Please stay in touch. Our theme music is by So Wiley. Additional music this week by Catherine Anderson, Peter Leonard, Bobby Lord, Emma Munger, Nathan Singapok, and Blue Dot Sessions. Fact-checking this week by Nicole Posolka. Thanks for listening. See you Sunday.